

Africa Is Not Poor. Africa Is Under-Processed.

The continent's export map, the value-addition opportunity,
and the strategic role of Africans living abroad

COMBINED EDITION — Part I: The AGF Report · Part II: Country Deep-Dive & References

~30%

of world mineral reserves
are in Africa

~75%

of world mined cobalt
comes from the DRC

~50%

of world cocoa comes from
Côte d'Ivoire + Ghana

\$3.4 tn

combined GDP of the AfCFTA
market of ~1.5 billion people

A single map of Africa's top exports tells two stories at once. The first is a story of **abundance**: nearly every country on the continent is a top-tier supplier of something the global economy cannot function without — cobalt, copper, cocoa, coffee, gold, oil, platinum, diamonds. The second is a story of **leakage**: almost all of it leaves the continent raw, which means the profit, the jobs, the technology, and the industrial capability are built somewhere else.

This report reads the map, quantifies the value-addition gap, and makes one argument above all: **the group best placed to close that gap — with capital, skills, networks, and market access — is the African diaspora.**

Prepared for the Africa Global Forum community · July 2026

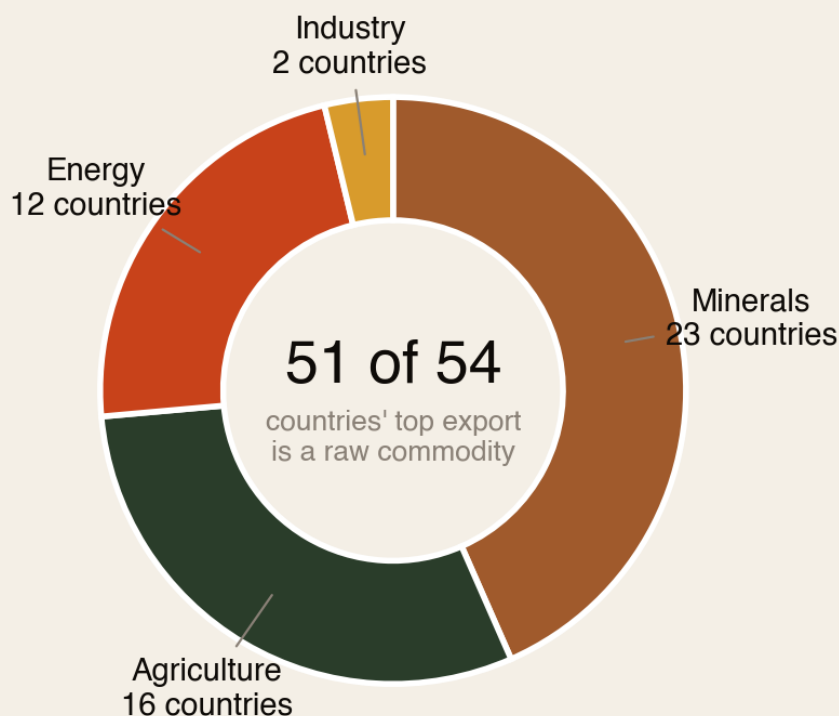
*Source material: "The Top Exports of African Countries" — Africap (2025), drawing on Afreximbank and TrendEconomy data.
Figures are approximate.*

1. Executive Summary

Africa's poverty is not a resource problem; it is a **position-in-the-value-chain** problem. Of the 54 countries on the Africap export map, 51 have a raw commodity — a mineral, a fuel, or an unprocessed crop — as their top export. Only two, Morocco (cars) and Tunisia (electrical wiring), lead with manufactured goods. Yet for every commodity Africa supplies, 80–90% of the final consumer value is created *after* the raw material leaves the continent.

The old story was extraction. The new story — industrialization, regional trade under the AfCFTA, and local ownership of value chains — is the largest untapped income stream on the continent. And the roughly 160–200 million people of African descent living abroad are not spectators to it: they are already Africa's largest external financier, its embedded skills pipeline inside the very industries that capture African value, and a built-in first market for African finished goods.

2. What the Map Shows: A Continent of Raw Inputs

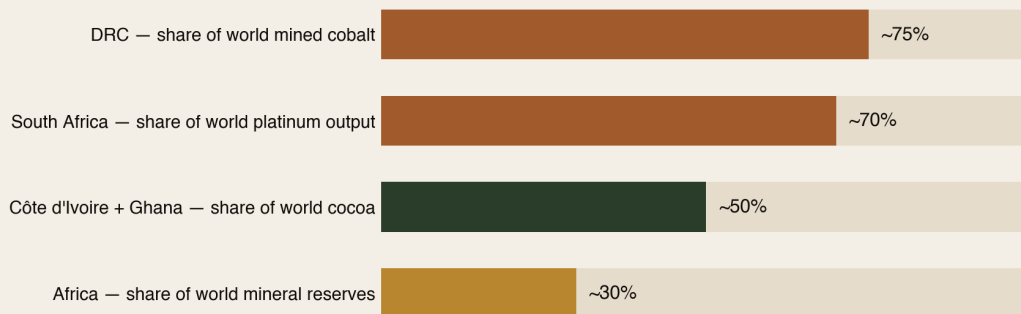


Top export of each African country by category, from the Africap map (2025). Categorization approximate.

Energy exporters (Nigeria, Angola, Algeria, Libya, Egypt, Gabon, Congo, Chad, South Sudan and others) fuel the world — while most import their own refined fuel. The mineral belt (DRC and Zambia's copper and cobalt, the gold economies of West and East Africa, South Africa's platinum, the diamond producers of the south) supplies the raw inputs of the energy transition and global finance. The agricultural exporters (Côte d'Ivoire's cocoa, Ethiopia's coffee, Kenya's tea, the cotton belt) grow what the world drinks, eats, and wears — then buy it back branded. Morocco and Tunisia are the exception that proves the rule: industrialization is possible, and it changes everything.

3. Africa's Grip on Global Supply

This is not a marginal supplier asking for inclusion. On several inputs the modern economy simply does not work without Africa:



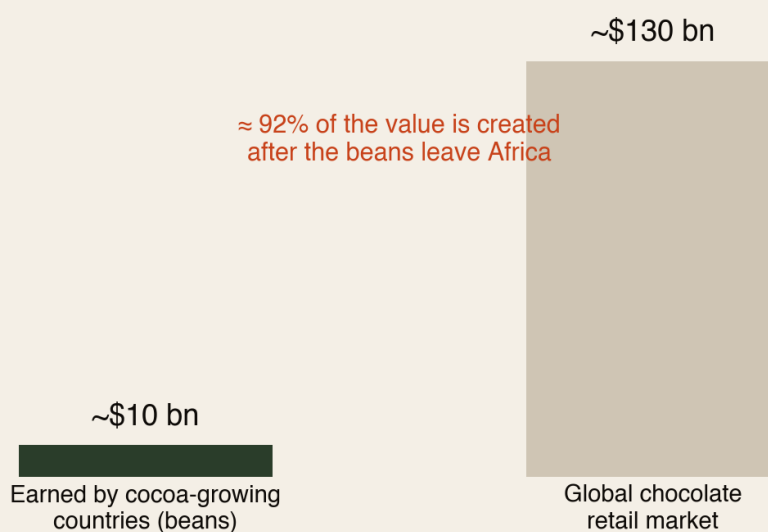
Africa's approximate share of selected global supplies. Sources: Africap map (2025), Afreximbank, industry estimates.

Add the AfCFTA — a single trading zone of roughly 1.5 billion people and \$3.4 trillion in combined GDP, the largest free-trade area by country count since the WTO's founding — and the pieces exist for continental-scale manufacturing: a factory in Accra or Kigali can, in principle, serve the whole continent without fifty tariff walls.

That is not a charity story. That is a power story.

4. The Value-Addition Gap: Where the Money Actually Goes

The economics of raw export are brutal and consistent across commodities. Cocoa is the clearest example: West Africa grows most of the world's cocoa, but the bean earns cents while the bar earns dollars — and the bar is made in Europe.



Approximate annual earnings of cocoa-producing countries versus the global chocolate retail market.

The same pattern holds elsewhere: Ethiopia earns a sliver of the retail price of a cup of its own coffee sold in London; the DRC exports cobalt ore while the battery plants and EV margins sit in Asia; Nigeria

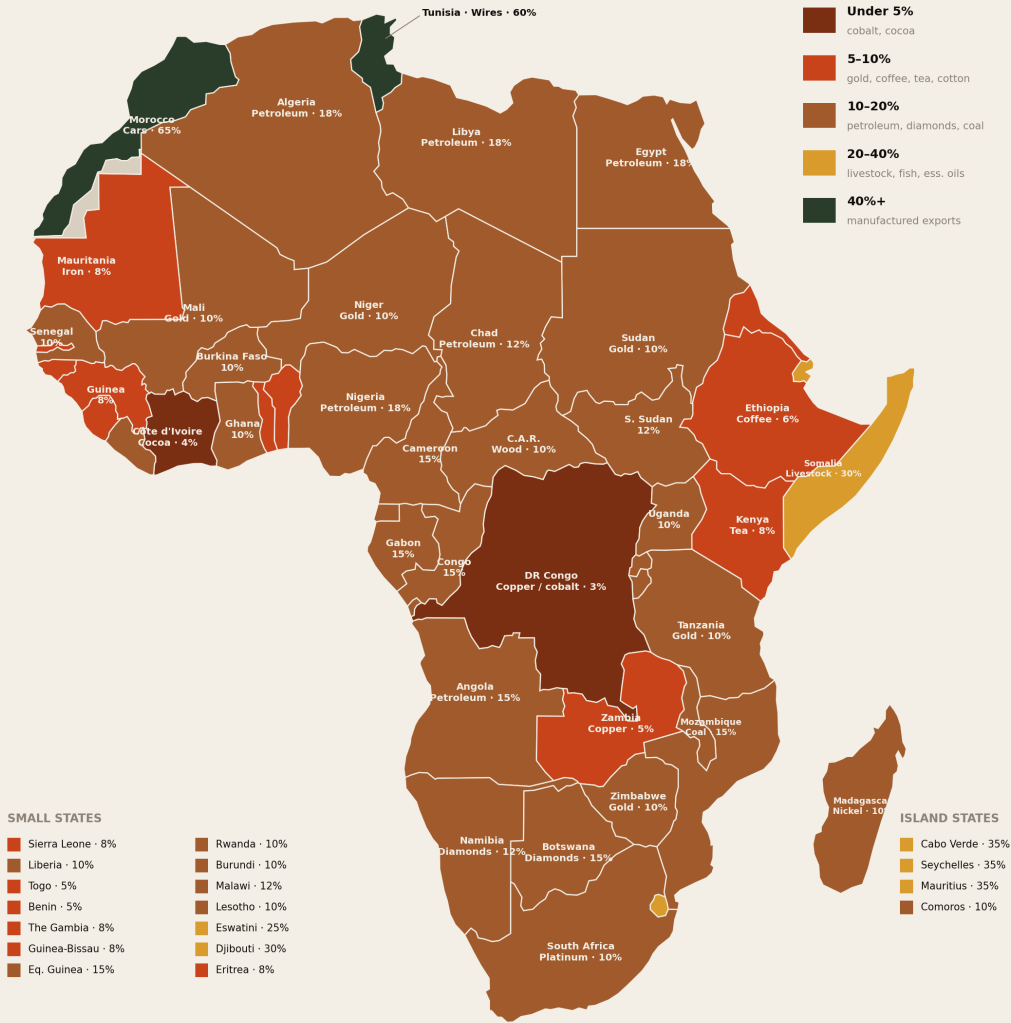
exported crude for decades while paying others the refining margin on its own resource — the scale of the Dangote refinery shows what reversing that takes.

Flip the famous “top exports” map around — colour each country by the share of its top export's final value that actually stays home — and the story becomes unmissable: a continent of single-digit reds and browns, with the industrialized north-west corner in green.

WHAT AFRICA TAKES HOME

Estimated share of each top export's final consumer value that stays in the exporting country

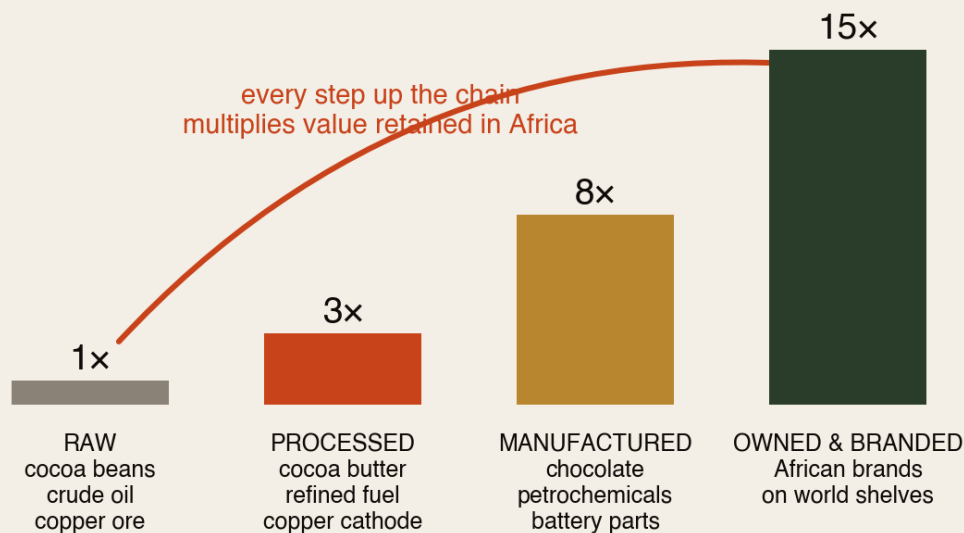
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Illustrative estimates anchored to published value-chain studies — DRC cobalt ~3%, cocoa ~4%, Ethiopian coffee ~6%, platinum ~8-10%, crude ~15-20% (UNDP, AfDB, Copperbelt Katanga Mining, Private Finance for the SDGs). Top export per country: Africap / Afreximbank / TrendEconomy, 2025. Western Sahara shown without data. Companion to “Africa Is Not Poor. Africa Is Under-Processed.” — Africa Global Forum, July 2026.

What Africa takes home — estimated share of each top export's final consumer value captured in the exporting country.
Illustrative estimates anchored to published value-chain studies.

5. The Ladder Africa Is Climbing



Illustrative value multiples along a commodity chain. Exact multiples vary by product; the direction does not.

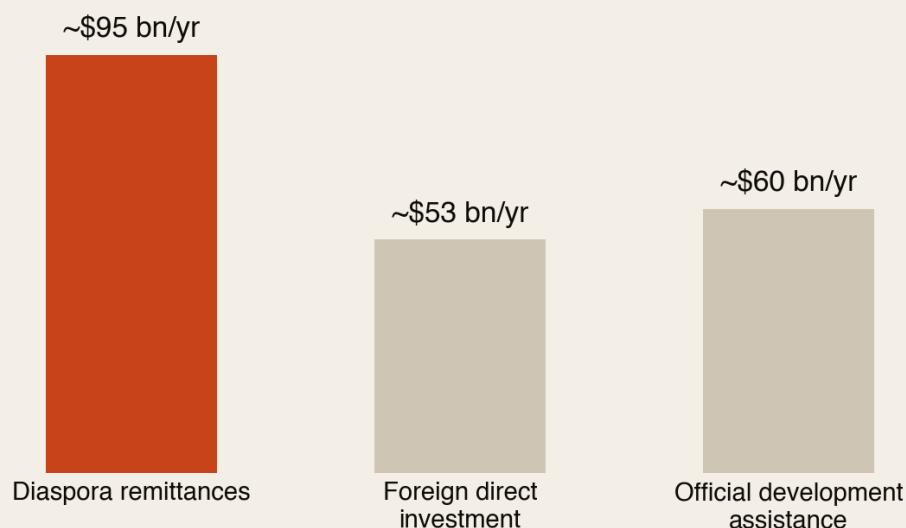
Copper becomes batteries. Cocoa becomes chocolate. Coffee becomes branded products. Crude becomes refined fuel. Cotton becomes textiles. The next wave of African wealth sits not in what Africa exports, but in **what Africa owns before it exports it**.

6. Why This Matters to Africans Living Abroad

This is the heart of the report: **the value-addition story cannot be written without the diaspora**. Six reasons.

6.1 The diaspora is already Africa's largest financier

External finance flowing into Africa (approx., recent years)



Remittances to Africa exceed both FDI and development assistance in most recent years (World Bank / UNCTAD / OECD orders of magnitude; approximate).

Remittances of roughly \$90–100 billion a year make the diaspora not a *potential* investor in Africa but its most reliable source of external capital already. The strategic question is whether that capital flows only

into consumption — school fees, rent, family support, all vital — or whether a growing share moves into productive assets: processing plants, agribusinesses, logistics firms, brands. **The shift from remittance to investment is the diaspora's version of the shift from raw export to finished product.** Same story, personal scale.

6.2 The diaspora holds the skills the value chain needs

Moving from exporting cocoa to exporting chocolate requires food scientists, packaging engineers, brand managers, supply-chain specialists, and trade lawyers. Africans abroad work right now inside the very companies that capture African value — in manufacturing, finance, tech, pharma, and logistics across Europe, North America, the Gulf, and Asia. Every one of those professionals is a walking transfer of exactly the know-how the continent's industrialization requires.

6.3 The diaspora IS the market access

The hardest part of selling a finished African product abroad is not making it — it is distribution, trust, and shelf space. The diaspora is a built-in first market of tens of millions of consumers, plus a sales force embedded in every major city on earth. Buying African-owned brands abroad is value addition by another name.

6.4 The diaspora shapes the narrative — and narrative shapes capital

Investment follows perception. As long as the dominant global story about Africa is charity, the capital that arrives will be charity-shaped: small, conditional, extractive. When the story becomes “the supplier of the world's critical inputs is moving up the value chain,” the capital becomes investment-shaped. Africans abroad sit inside the newsrooms, banks, universities, and boardrooms where that perception is formed. Telling the power story is not PR; it is an economic act.

6.5 The diaspora can broker the partnerships

Morocco's car industry was built on structured partnerships with global automakers. The next wave — battery precursors on the DRC–Zambia copperbelt, cocoa processing in Abidjan and Tema, textile mills along the cotton belt — needs brokers who understand both sides: how a German, American, or Korean firm thinks, and how business actually gets done in Lagos or Lusaka. That commercial and cultural bilingualism is the diaspora's native skill.

6.6 Networks compound what individuals scatter

Individual effort scatters; organized networks compound. Turning dispersed diaspora capacity into coordinated economic force is precisely the function of communities like the Africa Global Forum.

7. What a Diaspora Member Can Do — Starting This Year

- 1. Redirect a slice of capital.** Even 10% of annual remittances shifted toward diaspora bonds, investment clubs, or equity in African processing and manufacturing ventures changes the math at scale.
- 2. Adopt one value chain.** Pick the sector you work in abroad and map it onto your home country's raw export. That intersection is your highest-leverage contribution.
- 3. Buy and stock African-owned finished brands** — and get them into the stores, offices, and events where you live.

4. Transfer skills deliberately. Mentor, advise remotely, teach, sit on boards, or take a secondment. Knowledge is the one export that multiplies rather than depletes.

5. Tell the power story in your workplace, network, and platforms. Correct the charity framing when you encounter it.

6. Organize. Join and build diaspora networks that pool capital, deals, and expertise rather than acting alone.

8. Who Moves First?

Mover	Why
Morocco & Tunisia	Already industrialized exporters; the task is deepening and spreading the model.
Côte d'Ivoire & Ghana	Cocoa grinding capacity is already growing; branded chocolate for AfCFTA and diaspora markets is the nearest-term win.
Ethiopia & Kenya	Strong origin brands in coffee and tea; the leap to roasted, packaged, branded is short and high-margin.
DRC–Zambia corridor	The biggest prize (battery precursors) but the heaviest infrastructure need; regional cooperation is the unlock.
Nigeria	Dangote-scale refining, the continent's largest domestic market, and its most globally distributed diaspora.

The realistic pattern: agriculture-based value addition moves first (lower capital intensity, existing skills); minerals processing follows (capital-heavy, infrastructure-dependent) — with the AfCFTA as the demand engine and the diaspora as the capital, skills, and market bridge throughout.

9. Conclusion

The map's lesson is not that Africa needs help. It is that Africa is already indispensable — and indispensability that stops at the raw stage is wealth donated to someone else's economy. For the 160+ million Africans abroad, the message is direct: **you are not outside this story. You are its financing arm, its skills pipeline, its first export market, and its narrator.**

The continent's move up the value chain and the diaspora's move from remitter to owner are the same move — made from two sides of the ocean.

PART II

Country Deep-Dive: Who Is Best Positioned to Move from Raw Exports to Finished Products First?

The following annex expands Part I's "Who Moves First?" question into a fully referenced, country-by-country analysis: Morocco's automotive blueprint, the DRC–Zambia battery-materials hub, Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana's cocoa-to-chocolate push, Nigeria's Dangote refining revolution, South Africa's platinum-to-fuel-cell pivot, and Ethiopia's coffee and textiles play — plus sector value multipliers, the structural headwinds, and 36 cited sources.

Research annex compiled with Perplexity from Afreximbank, AfDB, World Bank, UNECA, WEF, and AfCFTA Secretariat sources. Retains its original formatting.

Africa Is Not Poor. Africa Is Under-Processed.

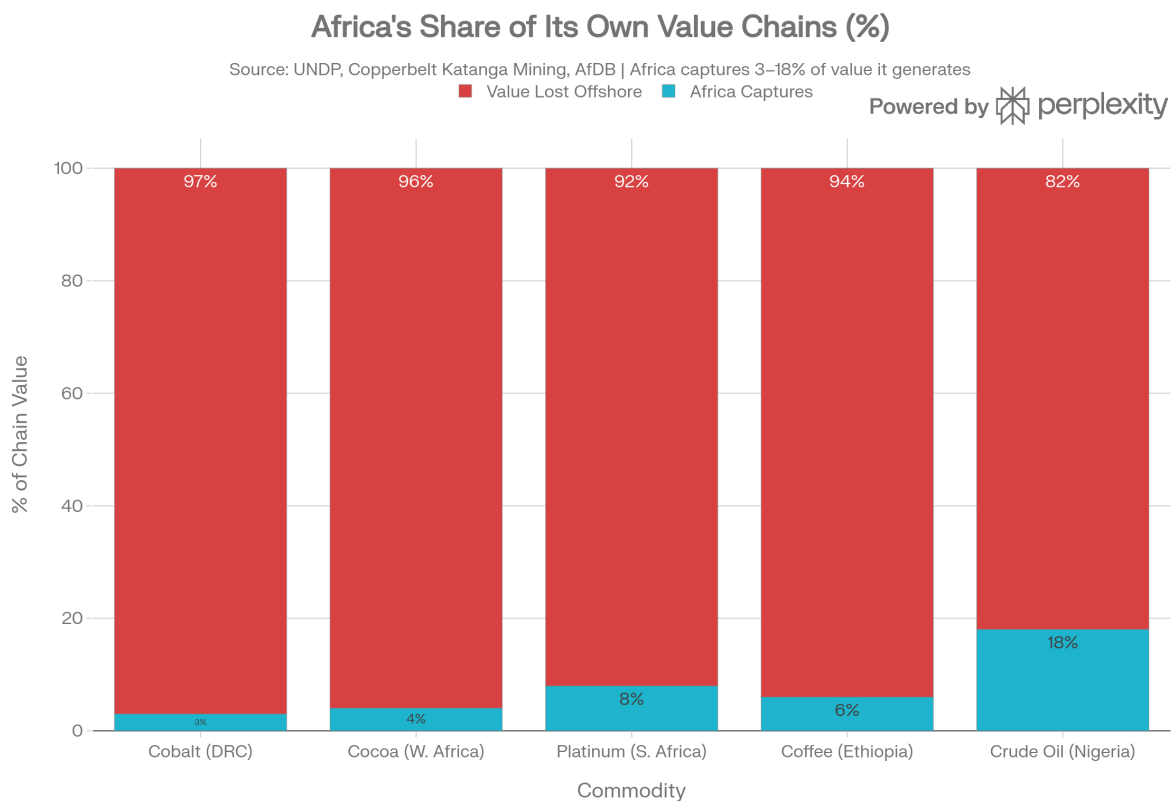
Who Is Best Positioned to Move from Raw Exports to Finished Products First?

Executive Summary

Africa does not have a resource problem. It has a processing problem. The continent holds approximately 30% of the world's known mineral reserves and an estimated \$29.5 trillion in mine-site mineral value, yet it captures less than 5% of its own value chains. The pattern is as old as colonialism: raw materials leave African ports and return as high-priced finished goods. But that story is changing — and for the first time in history, the economic, political, and institutional conditions are aligning to reverse it.^{[1][2][^3]}

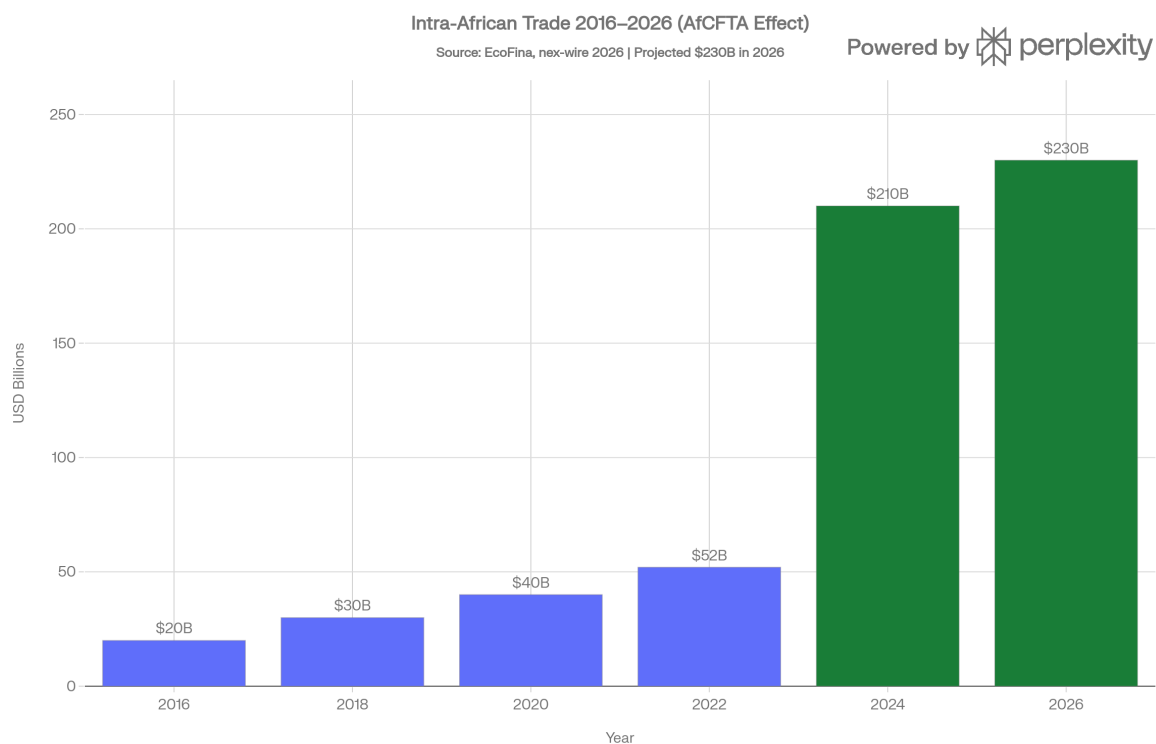
This report examines the six most compelling African industrialization cases — Morocco, DRC/Zambia, Côte d'Ivoire/Ghana, Nigeria, South Africa, and Ethiopia — and identifies which nations are best positioned to lead Africa's transition from raw exporter to finished-goods producer.

The Scale of the Missed Opportunity



To understand why value addition matters, consider the numbers:

- **Cobalt:** The DRC holds roughly 70% of the world's cobalt reserves and accounts for ~74% of global cobalt mine output, yet captures only 3% of the global cobalt value chain — a chain expected to reach \$300 billion per year by 2030.^{[4][5][^6]}
- **Cocoa:** Côte d'Ivoire produces approximately 40% of the world's cocoa beans, yet captures only about 4% of the \$100 billion global chocolate industry's value.^[^7]
- **Platinum:** South Africa holds 80% of global platinum group metal reserves, yet the bulk of refining and manufacturing of platinum-based components occurs in Europe and Japan.^[^8]

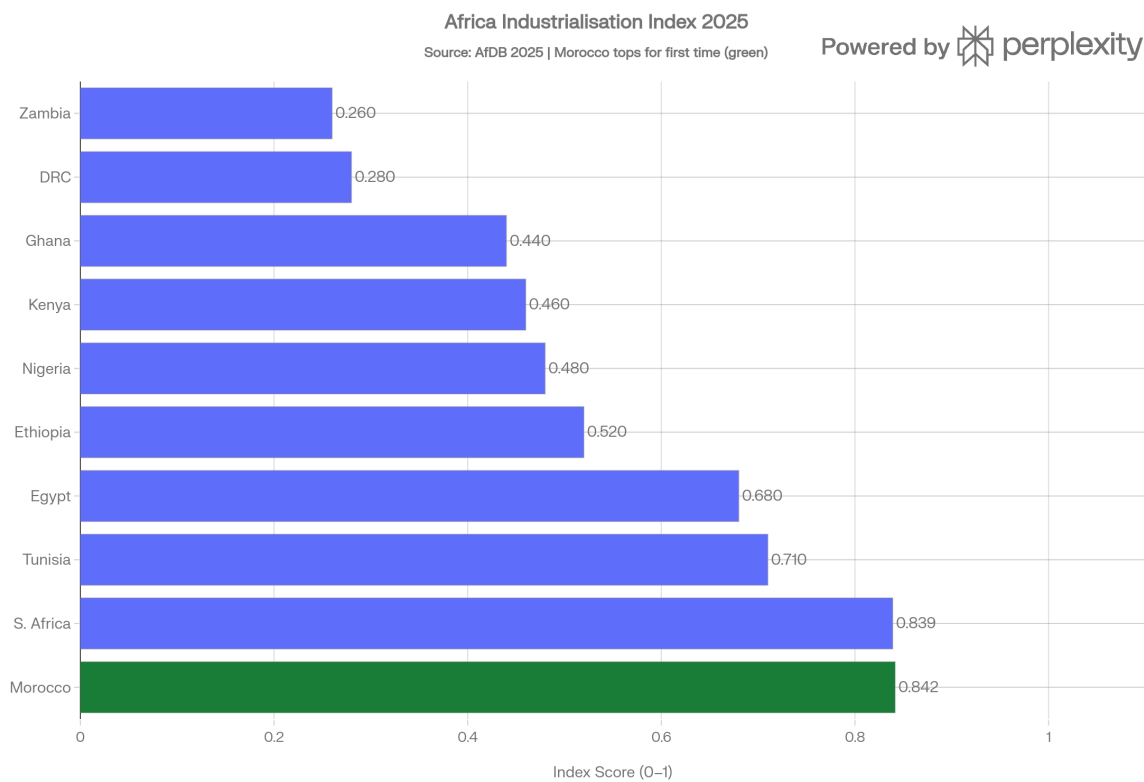


In 2022, raw materials constituted nearly half of Sub-Saharan Africa's total exports, while its imports were dominated by finished consumer and capital goods. Africa's intra-regional trade stands at just 15–18% of its total trade, compared to more than 60% in Asia and 70% in Europe. Processing raw materials domestically would not only boost export earnings — it would create jobs, stabilize commodity-dependent revenues, and reduce reliance on costly imports. Agroprocessing alone can add up to 40% to the value of local crops.^{[9][4]}^[^10]

The AfCFTA connects a market of 1.3 billion people with a combined GDP of \$3.4 trillion and promises to boost intra-African trade by 45% and generate a cumulative GDP gain of \$450 billion by 2035. Intra-African trade is already projected to reach \$230 billion in 2026, driven by manufacturing and agri-food sectors. This is the structural tailwind behind Africa's industrialization push.^{[11][12][13][14]}

Country-by-Country Ranking: Who Leads the Pack?

1. Morocco — The Industrialization Blueprint

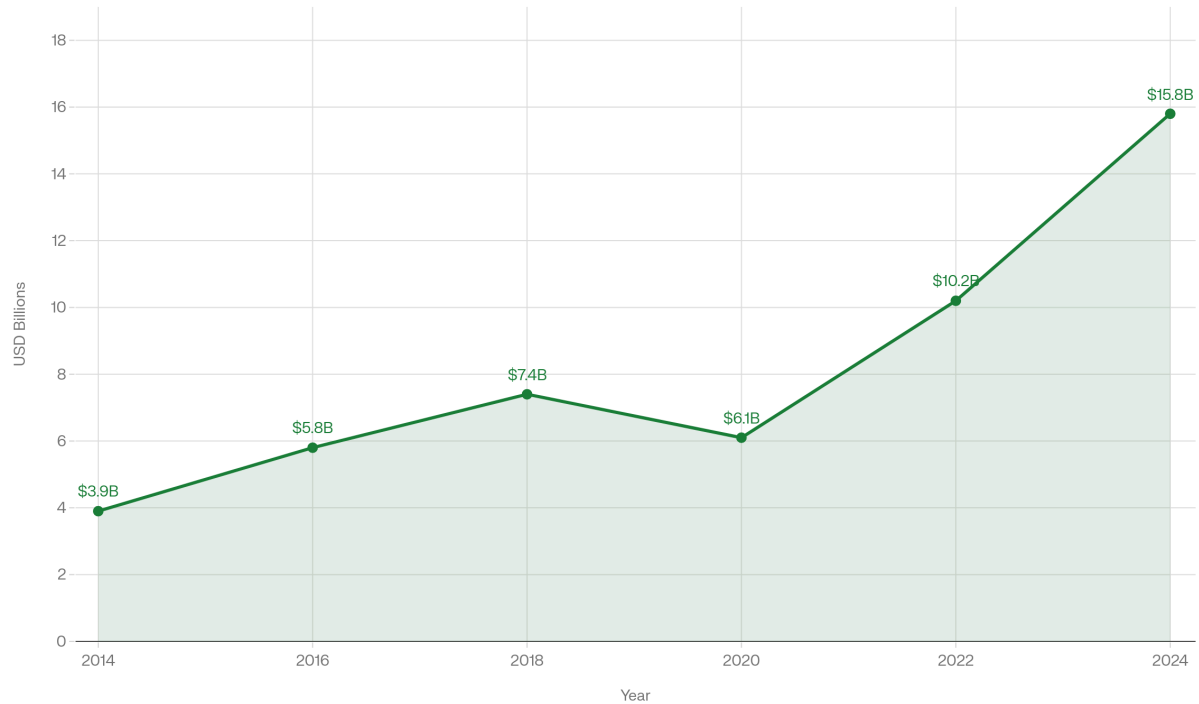


Morocco is the continent's most advanced example of the raw-to-finished transition — and in 2025, it officially topped Africa's Industrialisation Index for the first time, surpassing South Africa with a score of 0.8415, the first change at the top since 2010.^[^15]

Morocco: Automotive Exports 2014–2024

Source: Statista, ARSO | 4× growth in a decade

Powered by  perplexity



The crown jewel is Morocco's automotive sector. From virtually nothing two decades ago, the country's car industry generated **€15 billion (~\$16.3B) in export revenues in 2024**, versus just €3.6 billion in 2014 — a fourfold jump in a decade. In the first four months of 2026 alone, Morocco's automotive exports reached **\$6.3 billion**, up 18.6% year-on-year, with manufacturing activities surging 33.5%. About **1 million vehicles were manufactured in Morocco in 2025**, with 95% of exports destined for Europe.^{[16][17][18]}

The country hosts Renault and Stellantis assembly plants and is attracting next-generation EV investment. China's Gotion High-Tech is building a **\$6.4 billion battery gigafactory** in Morocco, projected to create 25,000 jobs. Tesla is also in planning stages for an **electric car assembly plant in Kenitra**. Industrial Info Resources tracks **18 active capital projects worth nearly \$8 billion** in Morocco's automotive sector alone. Morocco aims to double its production capacity to **2 million cars by 2030**.^{[19][18]}

What makes Morocco the blueprint? A combination of geographic proximity to Europe, government-backed free trade zones, tax incentives on EVs, investment in vocational training, and a 10-year industrial strategy that prioritized automotive, aerospace, and green energy. Morocco proved that an African country can go from zero to global automotive hub with the right industrial policy.

❑ 2. DRC + Zambia — The Battery Hub with Untapped Power

Copper and cobalt are the minerals of the 21st century. DRC and Zambia together hold the world's most critical reserves: DRC produces ~74% of global cobalt and Zambia is a major copper powerhouse. Yet the DRC captures only 3% of the cobalt value chain — leaving hundreds of billions on the table as China controls ~68% of global refined cobalt capacity.^{[4][5]}

The transformation has officially begun. In March 2025, Zambia and DRC signed a **landmark agreement to establish a joint Battery-Materials Manufacturing Hub**, with processing plants set to refine raw materials into battery-grade components for the global EV supply chain. The initiative is backed by Afreximbank, UNECA, and private investors, with a Special Economic Zone being developed in Ndola (Zambia) and Kipushi (DRC). Zambia's President Hichilema stated plainly: *"This partnership aligns with our goal to move up the value chain and maximize the benefits of our mineral resources."*^{[20][21]}

The DRC earned roughly **\$2.4 billion from cobalt exports in 2023**, while refined cobalt compounds — mostly processed in China — were worth **nearly twice as much at \$4.78 billion**. If this joint hub succeeds in processing battery-grade precursors locally, the revenue uplift would be transformational. The AfCFTA Secretary-General Wamkele Mene called the DRC-Zambia initiative *"transformative"* and confirmed Afreximbank has made **significant investment** in supporting it.^{[9][4]}

The challenge: DRC's political instability, infrastructure deficit, and the dominance of Chinese processing capacity create formidable obstacles. But the geopolitical tailwinds — global EV demand, the U.S.-Africa minerals partnerships, and the Lobito Corridor infrastructure project — are aligning in favor of this hub.^[^22]

❑ 3. Côte d'Ivoire + Ghana — Cocoa to Chocolate

West Africa is the world's cocoa kitchen. Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana together produce nearly 50% of the world's cocoa — yet for decades, they exported raw beans while European confectioners captured the value. That pattern is now being deliberately dismantled.^[^4]

In July 2025, Côte d'Ivoire inaugurated a **\$233 million cocoa processing facility** spanning 21 hectares, with an initial capacity of 50,000 tonnes of cocoa beans scaling to 210,000 tonnes of cocoa paste, butter, and powder within two years. The Conseil du Café-Cacao even placed a **temporary ban on raw bean exports** during the 2023/2024 harvest season to prioritize supply for local processors — an unprecedented move signaling political will. Côte d'Ivoire now processes **over 50% of its cocoa locally**, with a target of **100% local processing by 2030**.^{[23][24]}

Ghana is catching up fast. President Mahama has announced an ambitious plan to exceed Côte d'Ivoire's 50% processing benchmark within five years. Ghana processes approximately 45% of cocoa domestically, though high-value finished-goods production (chocolate bars, branded beverages) remains at just ~5% of output. The business case is overwhelming: **value-added cocoa products such as cocoa powder, butter, and chocolate can fetch up to five times the price of raw beans**. In November 2025, the African Union Commission, ECOWAS, and UNECA jointly launched a **cross-border cocoa and rice processing initiative** between Ghana and Côte d'Ivoire — the continent's first strategic cross-border agro-industrial value chain.^{[25][26][27][24]}

What must happen next: The shift from semi-processed intermediates to fully branded finished goods — "Made in Africa" chocolate bars on global supermarket shelves — requires deeper investment in cold chains, packaging, brand development, and access to retail distribution networks. The infrastructure is being built; the brands must follow.

4. Nigeria — Crude to Refined: The Dangote Revolution

Nigeria is Africa's largest oil producer, yet for decades it imported refined petroleum at massive cost. The **Dangote Petroleum Refinery** — at 650,000 barrels per day, Africa's largest refinery and one of the world's largest — has begun to fundamentally reverse that. By May 2026, the refinery was producing an average of **44.7 million litres of PMS (petrol) daily**, supplying 41.5 million litres domestically while also exporting diesel and aviation fuel internationally.^{[28][29]}

Dangote has announced plans to expand capacity to **1.4 million barrels per day**, which would make it the largest refinery in the world upon completion. Aliko Dangote's stated goal is clear: *"Nigeria will be able to refine all its crude locally and export finished products to other countries."* Polypropylene and petrochemical production will scale to 2.4 million metric tonnes, with applications in detergents, lubricants, and industrial chemicals.^[^30]

Beyond oil, Nigeria's manufacturing sector contributes just 8–9% to GDP despite a consumer market of over 200 million people — an immense gap that represents equally immense upside for FMCG, packaging, and industrial production. The AfCFTA has already catalyzed pharmaceutical hub development in Nigeria, with fill-to-finish vaccine manufacturing scaling significantly.^{[31][14]}

Nigeria's challenge is consistency: governance risks, infrastructure gaps, and currency instability have historically undermined industrial projects. But the Dangote model — private-sector led, at massive scale — provides a replicable blueprint for other commodity-processing sectors.

5. South Africa — Platinum, Fuel Cells, and Industrial Depth

South Africa remains Africa's most industrially mature economy, holding the world's largest reserves of **platinum group metals (PGMs), chromium, and manganese** — and 80% of global platinum group reserves. The country has long had beneficiation aspirations, but implementation has been slow.^[^8]

That is starting to change in the green economy. South African spin-out companies such as **HyPlat** are manufacturing **advanced membrane electrode assemblies** — the core components of fuel cells and electrolyzers — using locally mined platinum. These finished technological products yield massively higher returns than selling raw minerals, with exports currently going to Europe and Japan. South Africa's manufacturing sector contributes about 13% to GDP, the highest on the continent, and its industrial depth across automotive components, chemicals, food processing, and mining equipment gives it the broadest manufacturing base.^{[32][33]}

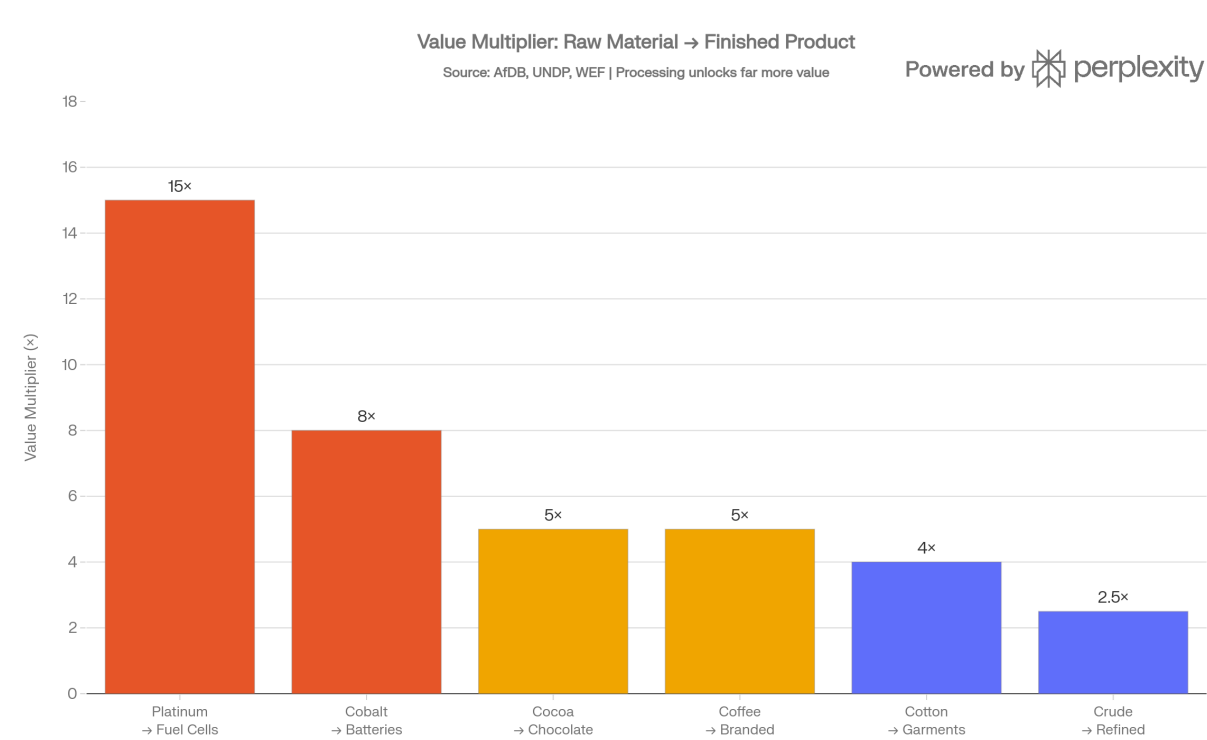
South Africa scored **0.839 on the 2025 Africa Industrialisation Index** (second only to Morocco), and while a long-term decline in competitiveness has been noted, its platinum-to-fuel-cell pivot, combined with its legal and financial infrastructure, makes it uniquely positioned for high-tech green manufacturing.[^15]

6. Ethiopia — Coffee to Brand, Cotton to Textiles

Ethiopia is Africa's largest coffee producer and the origin of arabica coffee itself. **Ethiopian coffee exports** generate significant foreign exchange, but raw bean exports dominate — capturing only the lowest margin of a global specialty coffee market worth over \$100 billion. The country has been pushing single-origin, branded coffee exports with growing success, with Ethiopian coffees commanding premium prices on platforms like Starbucks Reserve and specialty roasters globally.

On textiles, Ethiopia established industrial parks in Hawassa and Mekelle that attracted global apparel brands including H&M and PVH, transforming cotton and fabric into finished garments for export. The sector faced significant setbacks due to the Tigray conflict, but with reconstruction and renewed investment incentives, the potential remains enormous. **Cotton becoming textiles, then branded clothing**, is Ethiopia's most direct path to value addition at scale.

The Key Sectors: Where Value Is Being Built



Sector	Raw Export	Finished Product	Countries Leading	Value Multiplier
Automotive	Steel/aluminum parts	Assembled cars, EVs	Morocco	4–6x ^[16]
Cocoa/Chocolate	Raw cocoa beans	Cocoa butter, chocolate, beverages	Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana	Up to 5x ^[26]
Copper/Cobalt	Raw ore	Battery precursors, EV batteries	DRC, Zambia	2–10x ^[4]
Petroleum	Crude oil	Refined fuels, petrochemicals	Nigeria	2–3x ^[30]
Platinum	Raw PGMs	Fuel cells, catalysts	South Africa	10–20x ^[32]
Coffee	Raw beans	Branded single-origin, packaged	Ethiopia	3–8x
Cotton	Raw fibre	Textiles, garments	Benin, Ethiopia	3–5x ^[9]
Leather/Hides	Raw hides	Footwear, leather goods	COMESA region	3–4x ^[34]

What Separates Leaders from Laggards?

The countries moving fastest share four structural advantages:

- 1. Political will and industrial policy.** Morocco's automotive success is the product of a 10-year government strategy with tax breaks, free trade zones, and OEM partnerships. Côte d'Ivoire's raw-bean export ban is the most radical policy signal in Africa's agro-processing history. DRC and Zambia have institutionalized their battery hub via a formal intergovernmental agreement with UNECA and Afreximbank.^{[21][18][24]}
- 2. Strategic infrastructure.** Morocco's port infrastructure and proximity to Europe reduces logistics costs. The Lobito Corridor in Angola is being built precisely to connect DRC and Zambia copper-cobalt mining regions to Atlantic shipping routes. Without roads, reliable power, and port capacity, no industrialization strategy survives contact with reality.^{[19][22]}
- 3. Energy access.** Nearly half of Africa's population lacks electricity, and industrial processing is energy-intensive. Countries with energy solutions — Morocco's solar capacity, DRC's Congo River hydropower potential, South Africa's grid — have structural advantages. The Grand Inga Dam, if completed, could unleash 40GW — enough to power large-scale regional industrial growth.^{[35][19]}
- 4. Regional integration via AfCFTA.** The AfCFTA has added an estimated 0.5 percentage points to Africa's GDP growth in 2022, unlocked \$600M+ in automotive assembly investments in Ghana and Kenya, and is projected to double intra-African trade to one-third of total trade by 2035. Regional value chains — where mining happens in DRC, processing in Zambia, component manufacturing in South Africa, and assembly in Morocco — are only possible with continental trade integration.^[14]

The Structural Headwinds

Honest analysis must name the obstacles:

- **Fiscal pressure:** Many African governments depend on raw commodity export taxes for immediate revenue, creating political resistance to export bans or processing mandates that reduce short-term income.[^4]
- **Infrastructure deficit:** Power cuts, poor transport, and inadequate port capacity raise the cost of industrial production across most of Sub-Saharan Africa.[^36]
- **China's dominance in processing:** China controls ~68% of refined cobalt capacity and is the dominant player in battery precursor manufacturing. Dislodging this requires technology transfer agreements, competitive financing, and coordinated continental strategy.[^4]
- **Finance gaps:** Moving from raw material extraction to processing requires larger capital, longer investment horizons, and more sophisticated financing structures than traditional commodity trade finance.[^24]
- **Intra-African trade barriers:** Despite AfCFTA, non-tariff barriers, logistics costs nearly double the global average, and fragmented regulatory standards continue to impede cross-border manufacturing value chains.[^10][14]

Conclusion: The Verdict

Morocco is the best-positioned country today to lead Africa's transition from raw exporter to finished-goods manufacturer — it has already done it in automotive, is building for EV, and has the institutional, geographic, and infrastructure foundations to sustain it.

DRC + Zambia represent the highest-stakes opportunity on the continent. If the joint battery hub succeeds, it could unlock hundreds of billions in cobalt and copper value that currently flows to China — and position Central Africa as the battery capital of the clean energy transition.

Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana are making the most visible policy moves in agriculture, with state-level intervention (export bans, new processing plants) signaling serious intent to capture chocolate value domestically.

The deeper truth is this: Africa is not poor. It is under-processed. The continent feeds, fuels, and supplies the world's most critical industries — and it is beginning, at last, to demand its share of the value it creates. The question is no longer whether Africa will industrialize. The question is which countries will build the institutions, the infrastructure, and the political will to get there first.

"We have begun to see a positive change in this direction — and that is good news."
— Wamkele Mene, AfCFTA Secretary-General[^9]

Data sources: Afreximbank, African Development Bank (AfDB), World Bank, UNECA, World Economic Forum, AfCFTA Secretariat, Energy Capital & Power African Special Mining Report 2025, IIR News Intelligence, Horn Review, Accra Street Journal, and Zambia Parliament Ministerial Statements.

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